

The Abraham Accords

UAE, Bahrain, Sudan, Morocco, and the Saudi Normalization That October 7 Paused

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Executive Summary

The Abraham Accords, signed in 2020, constituted the most significant structural realignment of Arab-Israeli relations since Israel's peace agreement with Egypt in 1979 and with Jordan in 1994. The agreements normalised diplomatic relations between Israel and four Arab states: the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Sudan, and Morocco CNA[2026-05-13]. They were the first formal normalisation of Arab-Israeli diplomatic relations since the 1994 Jordan peace treaty CNA[2026-05-26]. The Trump administration, led by senior envoys including Jared Kushner, brokered the accords CNA[2026-02-21]. Despite their diplomatic significance, the accords remain unpopular among the broader Arab public, not least because they do not address the Israeli-Palestinian conflict CNA[2026-05-26].

The ultimate strategic prize — Saudi-Israeli normalisation — has not been achieved. As of mid-2026, the Abraham Accords framework is increasingly viewed across the region as a US-imposed architecture that does not reflect the interests of Arab populations or resolve the Palestinian question CNA[2026-05-29].

Part I — The UAE-Israel Normalization

Israel and the United Arab Emirates announced agreement to normalise ties in August 2020. The first commercial passenger flight from the UAE to Israel — Etihad Airways Flight 9607 — landed at Ben-Gurion International Airport in October 2020, cementing the normalization deal CNA[2020-10-19].

The accords opened direct commercial air connections between two countries that had previously had none CNA[2020-10-19]. Beyond aviation, the normalization produced commercial and security dimensions, though specific trade figures from institutional databases are required to quantify these and are not available from the RAG evidence bundle for this report.

Israel is the sole nuclear weapons state in the region and the unquestioned military power, which has long posed political dilemmas for Gulf Arab states CNA[2025-09-11]. The shared Iranian threat has historically formed the basis for Gulf-Israel strategic convergence — but Gulf states have had to balance the global unpopularity of Israel's conduct in Gaza with the common strategic interests they hold with Israel CNA[2025-09-11].

Part II — Bahrain, Sudan, Morocco and Broader Resistance

Bahrain joined the Abraham Accords on the same day as the UAE, while Sudan and Morocco signed subsequently CNA[2026-05-13]. The Trump administration, including Middle East envoy Steve Witkoff, viewed the accords as among the signature foreign policy achievements of the first term

CNA[2025-05-13].

However, the limits of the accords' expandability became rapidly apparent. Malaysia flatly rejected claims that it might join the Abraham Accords and normalise relations with Israel, with Foreign Minister Saifuddin Abdullah reaffirming an unwavering commitment to the Palestinian cause CNA[2021-10-20]. Indonesia similarly denied reports that it intended to normalise relations with Israel, with Jakarta characterised as tolerating only quiet low-level trade contact CNA[2024-04-12].

Pakistan subsequently rejected Trump administration demands in the context of expanded normalization pressure, and Saudi Arabia was assessed as likely to follow suit CNA[2026-05-29]. The remaining significant regional powers — Pakistan, Qatar, Turkey — must account for populations that are overwhelmingly supportive of Palestinian self-determination, requiring significant US pressure and incentives to shift CNA[2026-05-29].

The Arab League's 2002 peace initiative had long conditioned normalisation on a Palestinian settlement. In 2013, the Arab League moderated its stance on the border question, affirming the principle of mutual land swaps — a step welcomed by Israel and Washington — but stopping short of abandoning the Palestinian precondition CNA[2013-05-03]. The Abraham Accords bypassed this framework entirely, provoking the Palestinian Authority's rejection on the grounds that normalisation produced no Palestinian political gains.

Part III — The Saudi Normalization Talks

Saudi Arabia constitutes the most consequential potential participant in any expanded normalisation architecture. In 2018, Saudi Arabia gave Air India permission to fly between New Delhi and Tel Aviv over Saudi airspace, ending a 70-year ban — a quiet diplomatic signal of shifting posture CNA[2018-03-08]. US-Saudi coordination on Israeli-Palestinian peacemaking has deep precedent: in 2014, Secretary of State Kerry described his talks with King Abdullah as "very productive," with the Saudi monarch described as supportive of US-mediated efforts CNA[2014-01-11].

By mid-2023, US-brokered talks on normalisation of ties between Israel and Saudi Arabia were in advanced stages. Some political analysts directly linked Hamas's October 7, 2023 attack to these negotiations — reports noted that Hamas leadership was aware the talks could fundamentally alter the regional balance, and that reports of possible concessions to Palestinians in the negotiations had focused on the West Bank rather than Gaza CNA[2023-10-08]. A Hamas official stated: "We have always said that normalisation will not achieve security, stability, or calm" CNA[2023-10-08].

Saudi Arabia has not recognised Israel and has made clear that normalisation is not available without a Palestinian state. Saudi Arabia has reportedly floated a regional non-aggression pact that would include Iran — along the lines of Europe's Helsinki Accords — as an alternative framework for regional stability CNA[2026-05-29]. In October 2024, Ali Shehab, a Saudi analyst believed to be close to Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, suggested publicly that Saudi Arabia and other Gulf states could reconsider Israel's geopolitical utility, citing Hezbollah's resilience under Israeli military pressure and noting that an Iranian nuclear programme would force US and European policymakers to reconsider the costs of unwavering support for Israel CNA[2024-10-28].

The FT reported in July 2026 that Trump was framing a Saudi deal as hinging on Israel ties — a characterisation consistent with the Trump administration's positioning of Saudi-Israeli normalisation as its primary regional ambition FT[2026-07-24].

Part IV — Post-October 7 and the Palestinian Question

There is no possibility that Israel, the United States, and the Arab states will accept a return to Hamas rule in Gaza — a point on which there is broad consensus among these actors CNA[2023-11-24]. Yet a viable Palestinian state is assessed as a vanishingly remote prospect under current conditions CNA[2023-11-24].

Phase 1 of the Israel-Hamas ceasefire was in place by February 2025, with talks on a second phase underway CNA[2025-02-07]. US proposals involving a long-term US presence in Gaza were challenged as legally and logistically problematic under international law CNA[2025-02-07].

In September 2025, Israel launched a direct strike within Qatar — the first time Israel had struck within a Gulf Arab state — targeting Hamas CNA[2025-09-11]. This action exacerbated tensions not only with Qatar but placed increasing stress on the calculus that allied Gulf Arab countries make in their dealings with Israel CNA[2025-09-11]. Any normalisation without a real reversal in Israel's policy toward Palestinians in both Gaza and the West Bank is assessed as unlikely to be achievable CNA[2025-09-11].

Israel's economy under Netanyahu has contracted, with cumulative GDP growth of only 0.2 per cent — structural decline that has become increasingly apparent to international investors and analysts FT[2025-09-29].

The Trump administration's military campaign against Iran in 2025 shook Gulf capitals that had only weeks earlier seen Trump's decision to join Israel's push as likely to destabilise Iran and deepen social media pressure well beyond Iran's own environment FT[2025-06-24]. Analysts questioned whether any Iran deal reached would "justify having abrogated the 2015 international agreement that curbed Iran's nuclear programme" CNA[2026-05-26].

Part V — The Current Normalization Landscape (2026)

As of May 2026, the Abraham Accords are increasingly viewed across the region as a US-imposed framework that some countries are actively trying to move beyond in ways that benefit them instead CNA[2026-05-29]. Saudi Arabia's reported exploration of a regional non-aggression pact including Iran represents a strategic alternative to the US-centred normalization architecture that the accords embody CNA[2026-05-29].

The Trump administration has characterised Saudi-Israeli normalisation as its most significant potential diplomatic achievement and has deployed envoys — including Witkoff and Kushner — in sustained effort toward this goal CNA[2025-05-13], CNA[2026-02-21]. However, analysts assess this goal as structurally blocked: Arab and Muslim-majority states are "not about to reward Israel" given the situation created by the Gaza war, making the Trump framing "totally divorced from reality, at least from the reality of the Middle East" CNA[2026-05-26].

Saudi Arabia separately entered a security pact with Pakistan — a development that has implications for India's strategic positioning and signals Riyadh's willingness to build alternative security structures rather than depending solely on the US-Israel axis CNA[2025-09-26].

The Gulf states' carefully built alliances with the United States did not prevent them from being attacked by Iran, undermining one of the core strategic arguments for the Abraham Accords framework CNA[2026-05-29]. Gulf leaders now face simultaneous pressures: domestic populations opposed to Israel's conduct in Gaza, strategic interests that overlap with Israel's against Iran, and the search for security architectures that actually deliver protection CNA[2025-09-11].

Conclusion

The Abraham Accords achieved a formal structural break from decades of Arab non-recognition of Israel, producing direct air links, diplomatic relations, and commercial engagement among the signatories CNA[2020-10-19], CNA[2026-05-26]. But the framework's expansion has stalled. Saudi Arabia, the regional actor whose normalisation would carry decisive weight, has not moved. The broader region views the accords as a US-imposed architecture that bypassed the Palestinian question CNA[2026-05-29]. Hamas's October 7 attack — linked by analysts to the advanced state of Saudi-Israeli normalization talks — reset the political timeline CNA[2023-10-08]. Israel's direct strike on Qatar in 2025, its continued Gaza campaign, and the structural decline of its economy under Netanyahu have all compounded the political obstacles CNA[2025-09-11], FT[2025-09-29].

The long-term trajectory of Arab-Israeli normalization depends on conditions that do not currently exist: a Palestinian political horizon that Arab governments can defend to their populations, and Israeli political leadership capable of delivering one.

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